

PhD Policy of SMBBMUL



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Quality Enhancement Cell

SHAHEED MOHTARMA BENAZIR BHUTTO MEDICAL UNIVERSITY

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DEFINITION

Terms	Definitions
Committee	A committee constituted to perform duties in accordance with defined terms of reference
MPhil	A postgraduate degree (Level 7) awarded by a recognized institution following the successful completion of a defined program of study and research as stipulated by HEC.
PhD	A doctoral degree awarded by a recognized higher-education institution after the successful completion of a defined program of advanced coursework, research and thesis/Dissertation
Equivalent	As defined in the National Qualifications Framework, this is equivalent to level-7 and level-8 qualifications
Plagiarism	The practice of taking and using the thoughts, writings, or inventions of another person as one's own without given the credit to original author
Thesis/ Dissertation	A document presenting original research conducted by the candidate as part of the degree requirements.
GEP	Graduate Education Policy
HEC	Higher Education Commission
Force Majeure	An extraordinary event beyond control that disrupts normal academic or administrative activities.
University	Shaheed Mohtarma Benazir Bhutto Medical University Larkana (SMBBMUL)

• PURPOSE

The purpose of formulating a uniform PhD Policy at Shaheed Mohtarma Benazir Bhutto Medical University Larkana (SMBBMUL) is to establish a comprehensive framework that upholds the highest standards of academic excellence, integrity, and research quality in MS/MPhil (or equivalent) and PhD programs. This policy provides clear guidelines for the admission, supervision, and completion of MS/MPhil (or equivalent) and PhD programs in alignment with the rules, regulations, and guidelines of the Higher Education Commission (HEC) of Pakistan—the primary regulatory body for university academic programs—as well as other relevant professional councils and commissions governing various disciplines.

• ADMISSION

1. Minimum Academic Requirements For MS/ MPhil Or Equivalent Program:

- a. The candidate must have at least Sixteen years of schooling or minimum 4 year education after HSSC/F.A./F.Sc/Grade 12 or Equivalent shall be required for admission in the MPhil/MS or Equivalent program. With at least CGPA 3.0 (out of 4.0 in the semester system) or 1st division (in Annual system)
- b. The degree must be from an accredited institution, duly attested by HEC or the relevant council.
- c. SMBBMUL will: i. Conduct a rigorous admission test as an eligibility condition for admission to MS/MPhil/Equivalent programs, with a passing score of 50%. OR ii. Accept the GRE/HAT General/Equivalent tests, with a passing score of 50%.

2. Minimum Academic Requirements For PhD (Doctoral Degree):

- a. Prior to admission into a PhD program, the Scholar shall have been awarded MS/MPhil or equivalent degree with minimum CGPA 3.0 (out of 4.0 in the semester system) or 1st division (in Annual system) in MPhil or equivalent is required.
- b. The degree must be from an accredited institution, duly attested by HEC or the relevant council
- c. The Scholar pursuing MS/MPhil or equivalent degree from an accredited institution and interested in continuing to PhD may be granted provisional admission upon satisfaction with the Admission Committee regarding Statement of Purpose and students commitment to the PhD program, provided that confirmation of the admission shall be subject to the fulfillment of the following conditions within a period of one year from the date of provisional admission: i. Award of MS/MPhil degree, as prescribed in this policy. ii. Clearance of the admission test, along with the evaluation of the final interview, will determine the final results.

3. Admission Test:

SMBBMUL will announce the admissions for the Post graduate program through the Directorate of Post graduate studies and the University will i. conduct the subject test for admission in MS/MPhil and PhD programs, ii. Conduct the test equivalent to GRE/HAT General developed at the University, with the passing score of 60%. OR iii. the university may accept a test equivalent

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to GRE/HAT General, conducted by testing bodies accredited by HEC, with a passing score of 60%.

4. Statement of Purpose (SOP):

As part of the application for admission to PhD programs, applicants shall be required to submit a statement of purpose, which shall form an integral part of the application. The admissions committee shall use the information provided to ascertain the preparedness and interest of the candidate in pursuing doctoral studies, and whether the department has the requisite resources to train and supervise the doctoral candidate in the subspecialty in which the applicant is interested.

A statement of purpose shall, at least, include the following:

- i. Title of the potential research proposal.
- ii. A clear explanation of the applicant's current knowledge in the intended field, along with ideas for potential research
- iii. Explanation of the intended impact of the proposed research.
- iv. The prospective candidates shall demonstrate passion and enthusiasm for the area of research.

5. Weightage:

A final interview will be conducted, and admission shall be determined based on the combined weightage of the test score and the interview performance. The final results will be announced accordingly, with the weightage distribution as follows:

MPhil or equivalent		PhD	
Test	70	Test	50
Interview	30	SOP	30
Total	100	Interview	20
		Total	100

• COURSEWORK:

The following requirements shall be fulfilled before the award of a PhD Degree:

- a. The students shall complete the Coursework of at least 18 credit hours and 12 credit hours of Thesis.
- b. The course shall be offered through regular classes taught on campus by faculty members.
- c. The PhD degree should be based on research, not only on credit hours hence 12 credit hours has been awarded for Thesis/dissertation.

• COMPREHENSIVE EXAMINATION:

Following the completion of coursework, every candidate shall be required to pass the comprehensive examination to be granted candidacy as a researcher, with the provision that the student failing to pass the comprehensive exam, shall be allowed to retake the examination **once**

The passing marks for the comprehensive examination shall be **60%**

SMBBMUL will conduct a comprehensive test and following are the guidelines for a conducting a Comprehensive Examination:

- a. The exam should be based on the conceptual knowledge of the discipline to which the student is admitted.
- b. The exam shall cover the courses studied, preferably at the graduate level, conducted on one composite question paper.
- c. The evaluation shall be on an aggregate basis, expressed in terms of the number of marks awarded by the checker and only then he/she will be declared pass/fail
- d. After passing the comprehensive examination, the student shall submit the synopsis/research proposal within two (02) months and obtain its approval within six (06) months. The responsibility in this regard shall rest collectively with the MPhil (or equivalent) and PhD students. In case of non-compliance within the stipulated time, the matter shall be forwarded to the BASR for consideration of an extension of time, supported by proper justification by the student.
- e. The student/scholar shall be given the opportunity to choose a supervisor aligned with his/her area of research interest.

• PLAGIARISM POLICY

SMBBMUL has adopted the Higher Education Commission (HEC) Plagiarism Policy, and it is mandatory for all students engaged in research to adhere to this policy. The policy is also available for reference on the SMBBMUL website at <https://www.smbbmu.edu.pk/beta/policies>

• RESEARCH PUBLICATION

Under no circumstances shall a thesis based on plagiarized research be acceptable. It is the primary responsibility of both MS/MPhil / PhD researchers and their supervisors to prevent plagiarism.

For award of PhD degree, a PhD researcher shall be required to publish research articles meeting the following criteria:

- i. At least **1 (One)** research article in **W** category journal or **2 (two)** research articles in **X category** journals, (for Science disciplines). OR 1 (One) research article in X category journal or 2 (two) research articles in Y category journals (for Social Science disciplines)
- ii. The PhD researcher shall be the first author of these publications.
- iii. The research article shall be relevant to the PhD research work of the PhD researcher.
- iv. The article shall be published after approval of the research synopsis.

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• EXTERNAL EVALUATION OF PhD THESIS

The PhD Thesis Must Be Evaluated By:

- a. At least 02 (two) external experts who shall be:
 - i. PhD faculty member from the world top 500 universities ranked by the Times Higher Education or QS World Ranking in the year corresponding to thesis evaluation year
OR
 - ii. Pakistan-based Distinguished National Professors, Meritorious Professors from any national university; or professors from top universities ranked by HEC; or professors from any Pakistani University having a minimum H-Index 30 for Sciences, 15 for Social Sciences determined by Web of Science
- b. At least one external expert qualifying any one of the conditions mentioned at 'a' above if the PhD candidate publishes thesis research in a peer-reviewed journal that is classified by the HEC in category W for Sciences and X or above for Social Sciences.

The following general guidelines shall, at least, be observed while selecting external evaluator:

- i. **Relevance of Expertise:** in the same or related fields as in the thesis.
- ii. **No Conflict of Interest:** in personal, financial, or professional stakes in a particular decision or outcome.
- iii. **Objectivity:** capable of making unbiased evaluations.
- iv. **Diversity:** in terms of geography, culture, professional backgrounds etc.
- v. **Reputation:** must be good in the field, with a track record of fair and thorough evaluations.
- vi. **Availability:** should have the time and availability to review the thesis
- vii. **Professionalism:** capable of conducting themselves in a professional and respectful manner throughout the evaluation and defense process(if applicable).
- viii. **Communication:** capable of providing clear and constructive feedback on the thesis
- ix. **Confidentiality:** capable of maintaining confidentiality and protecting the intellectual property of the thesis
- x. **Compatibility:** well-versed with the research methodology, approach, and theories used in the thesis

• DEGREE COMPLETION TIMELINE

- i. The PhD degree shall be awarded by the universities not before the completion of 03 (three) years or six regular semesters and not after completion of 08 (eight) years or 16 regular semesters.
- ii. The completion date of PhD degree shall be reckoned with the date of notification of the award of PhD degree.
- iii. The maximum duration shall be determined from the date of student enrollment until the date of the completion notification of the PhD degree.
- iv. In case a student is unable to secure a PhD degree within the prescribed timeframe and claims for extension in duration, the university may constitute appropriate authority and determine the causes for delay. In event of force majeure i.e., delay on account of circumstance beyond the control of student, the university may grant an extension in the period of award of PhD degree in accordance with the duration limiting factor(s) and shall also take corrective measures in case the delay is caused due to process or administrative reasons.

• **GUIDELINES FOR THESIS/ DISSERTATION WRITING OF MPhil & Ph.D SCHOLARS**

S No.	Topic	Description
01.	Title	The title of the Thesis/Dissertation should be less than 30 words.
02.	Cover Page of Thesis/Dissertation	The Cover should only have listed supervisor who are designated on the Admission guidelines and the instructors group can be included in the training plan, and special circumstances need the approval of the graduate school.
03.	Thesis/Dissertation original statement and license statement	In order to ensure the authenticity and reliability of the thesis/dissertation as well as to avoid academic misconduct, authors and supervisor must sign the thesis/dissertation statement
04.	Table of contents	The content of the thesis/dissertation should be listed according to the three-level title of the thesis/dissertation. In addition, the text should be aligned to the left-hand side and the page numbers should be aligned to the right-hand side.
05.	Thesis/Dissertation content	Dissertation for academic and professional Master degrees should not be more than 20,000 and 15,000 words respectively. Doctoral thesis should not be more than 50,000 words. The thesis/dissertation should mainly compose of the following; Cover Page, the Thesis/Dissertation statement and copyright licensing, list of Acronym, catalog, abstract (in English language), Literature review, Introduction, Materials & Methods, Results, Discussion, Conclusion, Acknowledgement, References and Resume of the author.
06.	Abstract in English	The abstract is a concise introduction to the

	language	thesis/dissertation (in simple English language), describing the author's outstanding and creative achievements, and with 3 to 5 keywords. Abstract in English language should not be more than 2000 words. It includes; the title of Thesis/dissertation in English language, Background & Purpose, Methods, Results, Conclusions and Keywords.
07.	Literature review	This section of the Thesis/dissertation describe the reason(s) for the research work, history, purpose, research status at home and abroad, research results in related fields, current problems and trends. Literature review for Doctoral thesis and master's dissertation should not be more than 8,000 and 5000 words respectively.
08	Introduction	It is a summary of the purpose of the study, the range and view of the study with clear description of the objective. The value and theoretical framework, scientific method should as well be described.
09.	Materials and methods	The main materials, instruments and key steps required by or conducted in the research.
10.	Results	Statistical data should be analyzed and collated, not a statement of experimental data.
11.	Figures	The size of the figure(s) should be coordinated with the layout of the paper. It should not be too large or too small. It should be clear and scientific. The coordinates, and the "standard prescribed symbols or units" must be marked. Marked symbols and abbreviations must be the same as in the text. Each figure should have a serial number and a correct English title, located at the bottom of the figure.
12.	Statistical table	Statistical tables must be consistent with the provisions of statistics, the standard three-line table. The contents

		and items of the table should be presented reading from left to right, and the data is arranged in vertical columns. The table should have an English title and serial number (same as the serial number) at the top of the table. The annotations of the table should be below and aligned to the left-hand side of the table. Fonts should be Times New Roman, and 12 point in size for texts in English and SimSun,
13.	Abstract in English language	The abstract is a concise introduction to the thesis/dissertation (in simple English language), describing the author's outstanding and creative achievements, and with 3 to 5 keywords. Abstract in English language should not be more than 2000 words. It includes; the title of Thesis/dissertation in English language, Background & Purpose, Methods, Results, Conclusions and Keywords
14.	3 Literature review	This section of the Thesis/dissertation describe the reason(s) for the research work, history, purpose, research status at home and abroad, research results in related fields, current problems and trends. Literature review for Doctoral thesis and master's dissertation should not be more than 8,000 and 5000 words respectively.
15.	Introduction	It is a summary of the purpose of the study, the range and view of the study with clear description of the objective. The value and theoretical framework, scientific method should as well be described.
16.	Materials and methods	The main materials, instruments and key steps required by or conducted in the research.
17.	Results	Statistical data should be analyzed and collated, not a statement of experimental data.

18.	Figures	The size of the figure(s) should be coordinated with the layout of the paper. It should not be too large or too small. It should be clear and scientific. The coordinates, and the "standard prescribed symbols or units" must be marked. Marked symbols and abbreviations must be the same as in the text. Each figure should have a serial number and a correct English title, located at the bottom of the figure.
19.	Statistical table	Statistical tables must be consistent with the provisions of statistics, the standard three-line table. The contents and items of the table should be presented reading from left to right, and the data is arranged in vertical columns. The table should have an English title and serial number (same as the serial number) at the top of the table. The annotations of the table should be below and aligned to the left-hand side of the table. Fonts should be Times New Roman, and 12 point in size for texts in English and Sim Sun,
20.	Microscope images must indicate magnification or scale	Maps (protein, nucleic acid, etc.) and images should not be more than $\frac{1}{4}$ of the page with accurate English title, specific annotations, 300 dpi resolution and a serial number (at the bottom aligned to the left) as in the text.
21.	Discussion	It is the process of analyzing statistics and comparing them with domestic and international studies in the same area to form an argument. The arguments should be accurate, complete, objective, logical and concise.
22.	Conclusion	This is a concise summary describing the outcome of the research in the context of the objective of the research. The status, role, value and significance of the

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		research should be included in the discussion section and should not be included in conclusion section of the thesis/dissertation.
23.	Acknowledgement	This section should include those who assisted in executing the research, with clearly stating specific roles for being acknowledged. For example, "Thanks to David for his help in PCR experiments". This indicates respect for the labor of others.
24.	References	This includes a full list of citation used in text of the thesis/dissertation.. References must be marked in the article, the format of superscripts, such as [xx]. Reference format in the template.
25.	Resume	Introduce basic information and research results. The format of the reference can be found in the template.
26.	The specific writing and format of dissertations	The first level title is should be in Times New Roman, No.15 font size of 15 points, Bold and the title number with "1.", "2.". For example, “Literature review, Materials and methods” , the title number with "1.", "2."..... The second and third level titles should be in Times New Roman, font size of 12 points,, bold and the title number with "1.1, 1.2 ...", "2.1, 2.2 ..."; “1.1.1、 1.1.2”, “2.1.1、 2.1.2 a size of 12 points and the English text should be Times New Roman, and a size of 12 points.
27.	Page settings	Page margins; top: 3.2 cm, bottom: 3cm, left: 3.17cm, right: 3.17cm, Page direction: Portrait, Paper size: A4; width: 21cm, height: 29.7cm, Header and Footer: Odd and Even numbers, Page boundary; Header: 2.7c Footer: 2.2cm alignment: to the top.

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28.	Page number	At the bottom of the page, Alignment: middle, There is no page number on the cover.
29.	Typesetting	English Fonts: Times New Roman, and font size of 10.5 point. Character-spaces Scaling : 100%, Text spacing: standard, Text location: standard Paragraph, Alignment: Align at both ends, Indent 2 characters in the first line, Line spacing: 24 lb.

Reference Document:

The reference document for this policy is the HEC Graduate Education Policy 2023, available at <https://www.hec.gov.pk/english/services/faculty/Plagiarism/Documents/Graduate-Education-Policy.pdf>

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